

piece of code, developed specifically to break into your network.

E-mail exploit detection software analyses e-mails for exploits—i.e., it scans for methods used to exploit the OS, e-mail client or Internet Explorer—that can permit execution of code or a program on the user's system. It does not check whether the program is malicious or not. It simply assumes there is a security risk if an e-mail is using an exploit in order to run a program or piece of code.

In this manner, an e-mail exploit engine works like an intrusion detection system (IDS) for e-mail. The e-mail exploit engine might cause more false positives, but it adds a new layer of security that is not available in a normal anti-virus package, simply because it uses a totally different way of securing e-mail.

Anti-virus engines do protect against some exploits but they do not check for all exploits or attacks. An exploit detection engine checks for all known exploits. Because the e-mail exploit engine is optimized for finding exploits in e-mail, it can therefore be more effective at this job than a general purpose anti-virus engine.

An Exploit Engine Requires Fewer Updates

An exploit engine needs to be updated less frequently than an anti-virus engine because it looks for a method rather than a specific virus. Although keeping exploit and anti-virus engines up-to-date involve very similar operations, the results are different. Once an exploit is identified and incorporated in an exploit engine, that engine can protect against any new virus that is based on a known exploit. That means the exploit engine will catch the virus even before the anti-virus vendor is aware of its emergence, and certainly before the anti-virus definition files have been updated to counter the attack. This is a critical advantage, as shown by the following examples that occurred in 2001.

The Lessons Of Nimda, BadTrans.B, Yaha And Bugbear

Nimda and BadTrans.B are two viruses that became highly known worldwide in 2001 because they infected a colossal number of Windows computers with Internet access. Nimda alone is estimated